Washington's Farewell Address

President George Washington · September 19, 1796 · excerpts

Source: Avalon Project (Yale Law School), avalon.law.yale.edu/18th_century/washing.asp

As Washington prepared to leave office after two terms, he published a long letter — co-drafted with Hamilton and Madison — to 'Friends and Fellow Citizens.' He warned against three dangers he saw threatening the young republic: partisan faction, sectionalism between the regions, and entangling alliances with European powers. The address shaped American political culture for over a century.

Connect: The Articles of Confederation failed partly because Congress couldn't tax. How does Hamilton's plan directly address that weakness?

Key Passages

On political parties

> Let me … warn you in the most solemn manner against the baneful effects of the spirit of party. … It serves always to distract the public councils and enfeeble the public administration. It agitates the community with ill-founded jealousies and false alarms.

On sectionalism

> The name of AMERICAN, which belongs to you in your national capacity, must always exalt the just pride of patriotism more than any appellation derived from local discriminations.

On foreign alliances

> The great rule of conduct for us in regard to foreign nations is in extending our commercial relations, to have with them as little political connection as possible. … 'Tis our true policy to steer clear of permanent alliances with any portion of the foreign world.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The end of Washington's second term (1796): fights between Federalists and Democratic-Republicans, the Jay Treaty controversy, and the war between Britain and France.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The American people ('Friends and Fellow Citizens'); it was printed in newspapers as an open letter, not delivered as a speech.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Washington, the retiring first president and former general, who stood above party and worried that the young republic was fragile.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. HIPP analysis — Point of View: How does Washington's position as outgoing president shape what he chooses to warn about?

2. Identify TWO specific events of the 1790s that prompted these warnings.

3. Compare Washington's foreign-policy advice with U.S. behavior in any later period of your choice.